

Word family: **icon / icons / iconic / iconically / iconography / iconographic / iconoclast / iconoclasm**

Base word: icon

Plural: icons

Related forms: iconic, iconically, iconography, iconographic

Further lexical relatives: iconoclast, iconoclasm

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / related adjective and adverb forms (相關形容詞及副詞)

Your sentence:

> “So, although it may not be the most **iconic** building in Hong Kong...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **iconic** means **extremely well known and strongly associated with a particular place, culture, period, style, or identity, so that it becomes almost a symbol of it**.

繁體中文： **標誌性的；極具代表性的；一看到便會令人聯想到某個地方、時代、文化或身分的**

中文翻譯：

> “...it may not be the most **iconic** building in Hong Kong...”

「.....雖然它未必是香港最具**標誌性 / 代表性**的建築物.....」

Here:

iconic building = 知名度極高、辨識度極高，並能代表一個城市或地方形象的建築

1. **icon = sacred religious image (宗教) — 聖像；聖像畫**

This is the historically central meaning.

Meaning: A sacred image, especially a painted image of Christ, the Virgin Mary, or a saint in Eastern Orthodox Christian traditions.

Practice 1

> “The church contains several ancient **icons**.”

「這座教堂內有幾幅古老的**聖像**。」

Practice 2

> “The **icon** was displayed near the altar.”

「那幅**聖像**被陳列在祭壇附近。」

icon = 宗教中受到尊崇、用來描繪神聖人物的圖像，尤指東正教傳統的聖像

This should remain separate from the modern celebrity/computer meanings.

2. **icon** = person or thing regarded as a powerful symbol (象徵人物 / 事物) — 偶像；代表性人物；象徵

Icon can mean a person, object, building, work, brand, etc. that becomes highly recognizable and representative of a culture, period, style, movement, or field.

Practice 3

> “She became a fashion **icon**.”

「她成為時尚界的**標誌性人物 / 偶像**。」

Practice 4

> “The bridge is an architectural **icon**.”

「那座橋是一個建築界的**標誌性象徵**。」

icon = 因極高知名度、影響力或辨識度，而成為某個領域、文化、地方或時代代表的人 / 事物

Common:

- * cultural icon
- * fashion icon
- * pop icon
- * design icon
- * architectural icon

This is the major modern figurative sense behind **iconic**.

3. **icon** = greatly admired famous person (名人 / 偶像) — 偶像；傳奇人物

In everyday media language, **icon** often refers to a highly admired or celebrated person.

Practice 5

> “He is regarded as a music **icon**.”

「他被視為音樂界的**傳奇人物 / 偶像**。」

Practice 6

> “The actor became a global **icon**.”

「那位演員成為全球性的**標誌人物**。」

This overlaps with Meaning 2, but the emphasis is more on **fame and admiration** than pure symbolic representation.

For strict counting, I would merge it with #2.

4. **icon** = graphical symbol on a computer/device (電腦) — 圖示 ; 圖標

Icon is a very common computing term.

Meaning: A small graphical image on a screen representing a file, program, command, function, folder, etc.

Practice 7

> “Click the settings **icon**.”

「按一下設定**圖示**。」

Practice 8

> “Drag the file onto the trash **icon**.”

「把檔案拖到垃圾桶**圖標**上。」

icon = 電腦、手機或其他數碼介面中代表程式、功能、檔案或操作的小型圖像

Common:

- * app icon
- * menu icon

- * folder icon
- * icon bar
- * click an icon

This is a genuinely distinct modern core meaning.

5. **icon** = sign that resembles what it represents (符號學) — 像似符號；圖像符號

In semiotics, an **icon** is a sign that represents something through resemblance.

For example:

- * a portrait resembles the person;
- * a map resembles spatial relationships;
- * a pictogram resembles the object/action represented.

Practice 9

> “In semiotics, a portrait can function as an **icon**.”

「在符號學中，肖像可以作為一種**像似符號**。」

icon = 因外形、結構或特徵與所指事物相似，而能代表該事物的符號

This is a real specialist meaning and should be retained as a domain sense.

6. **icon** = visual pictorial symbol more generally (圖像符號) — 圖像；象徵性圖形

Outside strict computing, **icon** can also refer more broadly to a simple visual symbol.

Practice 10

> “The sign uses familiar **icons** for food and transport.”

「這個標誌使用了常見的食物和交通**圖像符號**。」

For strict counting, I would normally merge this with the computing/semiotic branch depending on context rather than create a separate core meaning.

Related form: **iconic**

Iconic has several highly useful branches.

iconic = extremely recognizable and representative (標誌性的) — 標誌性的 ; 極具代表性的

This is the exact meaning used in your passage.

Practice 11 — Original

> “It may not be the most **iconic** building in Hong Kong.”

「它未必是香港最具**標誌性**的建築。」

Practice 12

> “The tower has become an **iconic** part of the city skyline.”

「那座塔已成為城市天際線中極具**代表性**的一部分。」

iconic = 知名度和辨識度極高 , 以致能代表某個地方、文化、時代或類型

iconic = associated with a famous person/work/style (經典代表性的) — 經典而具辨識度的

Practice 13

> “She wore one of the singer’s most **iconic** outfits.”

「她穿上了那位歌手最具**代表性 / 經典辨識度**的服裝之一。」

Practice 14

> “The photograph became an **iconic** image of the era.”

「那張照片成為那個時代一幅極具**代表性的標誌影像**。」

This is the same core adjective sense.

iconic = relating to resemblance-based signs (符號學) — 像似的 ; 圖像性的

In semiotics, **iconic** can mean relating to a sign that resembles its referent.

Practice 15

> “The image has an **iconic** relationship to the object.”

「這個圖像與該物件具有**像似符號關係**。」

This is a specialist technical extension and is distinct from everyday “famous/representative.”

Related form: **iconically**

Iconically means in an iconic or highly representative way.

Practice 16

> “The building is **iconically** associated with the city.”

「這座建築與城市形象有極具**標誌性的**聯繫。」

This form is valid but comparatively uncommon.

Related form: **iconography**

Iconography has several established meanings.

iconography = visual images/symbols associated with a subject (圖像體系) — 圖像學；象徵圖像系統

Practice 17

> “The painting uses traditional religious **iconography**.”

「這幅畫使用了傳統宗教**圖像符號系統**。」

iconography = 某種宗教、文化、人物、主題或時期中反覆使用的一整套圖像和象徵

iconography = study/interpretation of visual symbols (藝術史) — 圖像學研究

In art history, **iconography** can also refer to the identification and interpretation of subjects, symbols, and imagery in works of art.

Practice 18

> “The course introduces Renaissance **iconography**.”

「這門課介紹文藝復興時期的**圖像學**。」

This is a specialist but established family branch.

Related form: **iconographic**

Iconographic means relating to iconography, visual symbolism, or traditional imagery.

Practice 19

> “The work contains rich **iconographic** detail.”

「這件作品包含豐富的**圖像符號細節**。」

Related form: **iconoclast**

An **iconoclast** originally meant someone who destroys religious icons.

It later developed an important figurative meaning:

someone who challenges established beliefs, traditions, or institutions

Practice 20

> “The artist was regarded as an **iconoclast**.”

「那位藝術家被視為一個**挑戰傳統的人 / 反傳統者**。」

This is lexically related but semantically independent enough to deserve its own future entry if targeted.

Related form: **iconoclasm**

Iconoclasm can mean:

1. destruction/rejection of religious icons;
2. figuratively, rejection of established traditions or beliefs.

Again, this is a lexical-family extension rather than another meaning of **icon**.

Important distinction: **icon vs symbol**

symbol

is the broad word for anything representing another idea or thing.

icon

can mean:

- * highly representative famous person/thing
- * computer pictorial symbol
- * sacred image
- * resemblance-based sign in semiotics

So every cultural **icon** functions symbolically, but not every symbol is an icon.

Important distinction: **icon vs idol**

idol

usually means a person greatly admired, sometimes excessively.

icon

suggests broader cultural importance, recognition, or representativeness.

- > teenage idol
- > cultural icon

A celebrity may be an idol to fans without being a cultural icon.

Important distinction: **icon vs celebrity**

celebrity

= famous person

****icon****

= person so recognizable/influential that they become representative of something larger

Fame alone does not automatically make someone an icon.

Important distinction: ****icon vs legend****

****legend****

when used for a person means someone celebrated for exceptional achievements or reputation.

****icon****

emphasizes symbolic/representative status and recognizability.

A person can be both.

Important distinction: ****icon vs emblem****

****emblem****

is a visual/object symbol conventionally associated with something.

****icon****

in the cultural sense can be a person, object, place, or image that becomes representative.

> national emblem

> cultural icon

Important distinction: ****icon vs logo****

****logo****

= designed graphic mark identifying a company, organization, product, etc.

icon

= small pictorial symbol representing a function/object, especially in interfaces.

A logo identifies a brand.

An icon typically represents an action, object, or concept.

Important distinction: **icon vs pictogram**

pictogram

= simplified picture conveying information

icon

= broader visual symbol, especially in interfaces

Many pictograms function as icons, but the terms are not identical.

Important distinction: **iconic vs famous**

famous

simply means widely known.

iconic

means not only widely known but also highly recognizable and representative.

> famous building

> iconic building

An iconic building has become part of a place's identity.

Important distinction: **iconic vs classic**

This is especially useful because **classic** is already in your database.

classic

emphasizes:

- * lasting quality
- * established status
- * enduring value

****iconic****

emphasizes:

- * recognizability
- * symbolic status
- * strong association with a place, person, style, or era

A design can be classic without being iconic, and iconic without necessarily being very old.

Important distinction: ****iconic vs distinctive****

****distinctive****

means easy to recognize because it has unusual/characteristic features.

****iconic****

goes further: it has cultural or symbolic importance.

A building can be distinctive but not iconic.

Countability note

****Icon**** is countable:

- > an icon
- > several icons

This applies across its major senses:

- * a religious icon
- * a cultural icon
- * an app icon
- * a semiotic icon

Useful construction: ****an icon of X —的象徵 / 代表****

Practice 21

> “The building became an ****icon of**** modern architecture.”

「這座建築成為現代建築的****象徵 / 代表****。」

Useful construction: ****cultural icon — 文化標誌人物 / 事物****

Practice 22

> “The character became a global cultural ****icon****.”

「這個角色成為全球性的****文化標誌****。」

Family-extension note

The practical modern family includes:

- * ****icon****
- * ****icons****
- * ****iconic****
- * ****iconically****
- * ****iconography****
- * ****iconographic****

More independent but clearly related:

- * ****iconoclast****
- * ****iconoclasm****

The important semantic sweep gives us four major conceptual areas:

1. sacred religious image
2. famous representative person/thing
3. graphical/interface symbol
4. resemblance-based sign in semiotics

Iconic then inherits both:

- * the everyday cultural “highly recognizable/representative” sense;
- * the specialist semiotic “resembling its referent” sense.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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icon — religious	宗教中受到尊崇的神聖圖像，尤指東正教聖像
icon — cultural/person/thing	因極高知名度、影響力或辨識度而成為某領域、地方、文化或時代代表的人 / 事物
icon — computing	電腦或手機介面中代表程式、功能、檔案或操作的小型圖示
icon — semiotics	因外形或特徵與所代表事物相似而具有意義的像似符號
iconic — everyday	極具辨識度、知名度和代表性，能象徵某地方、文化、時代或風格的
iconic — semiotics	因與所指事物具有相似性而形成的；像似符號性的
iconography	某主題 / 文化中的圖像象徵系統；亦指研究圖像象徵的藝術史方法
iconographic	與圖像符號系統或圖像學有關的
iconoclast	原指破壞聖像者；現亦可指挑戰傳統觀念的人

For your original sentence

> “Although it may not be the most **iconic** building in Hong Kong...”

The exact meaning is:

iconic = 建築物具有極高辨識度和知名度，而且能代表香港的城市形象

So:

> **an iconic building**

= 一棟具標誌性、極具代表性的建築物

The sentence does **not** merely mean:

> “the most famous building”

It suggests something stronger:

> **a building so recognizable and representative that it functions almost like a symbol of Hong Kong.**

For your database, I would count **4** genuinely useful core meanings for `icon`:

1. **sacred religious image**
2. **highly recognizable representative person/thing**
3. **graphical/interface symbol**
4. **semiotic sign that resembles what it represents**

For **iconic**, I would map **2** important meanings:

1. **highly recognizable and symbolically representative**
2. **semiotic: resembling the thing represented**

I would keep **iconography / iconographic / iconoclast / iconoclasm** as family or lexical extensions rather than inflate the base noun count.